

white, and certainly male. The AI system looked at this data, learnt from it, and therefore, became pre-disposed towards selecting white males.” The use of the AI algorithm was discontinued by Amazon after the issue came to light.

Troubled by Tech

Delta’s Gupta, who invests in

companies building emerging tech-based products and services, says that this bias needs to be identified and corrected in the development stages as the use of AI-based products and services becomes more ubiquitous. “As AI becomes more pervasive, this issue might grow manifold. You will see more instances of biases

against women as more tasks get automated via AI. Hence, there is a need for transparency around the data on which AI models are trained to ensure that the users are aware of the biases and their impact,” she says.

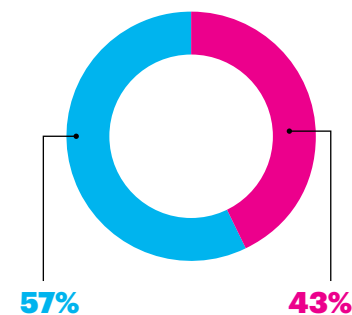
In that backdrop, Sray Agarwal, Principal Consultant-AI at Fractal Analytics, says that these biases can be identified and addressed by first ensuring that the data is clean. He says, “Data sets should be free of gender-specific information or any proxies that indirectly reflect gender.” This involves meticulous data-curation to eliminate biases. “Secondly, implementing rigorous tests throughout the data science and product development lifecycle is essential.” These tests, based on statistical analyses, help identify and rectify the biases at different stages of the process, ensuring that a system remains unbiased. He adds that seeking the approval of, or validation from, an Ethics Committee or Governance Council is also crucial. “This ensures an independent review of the AI system’s fairness and adherence to ethical standards, which works as a crucial layer of oversight and accountability.”

Apart from algorithmic biases, women are also likely to be disproportionately impacted by AI as automation takes over the workforce. Tech Whisperer’s Bindra reasons that since a lot of women tend to be in lower ranking positions in the tech industry, they stand to suffer more from the impact of new technologies like AI and automation. “Contact/call centre employees are usually women. Across the world, the ratio of women doing these jobs is high, and AI and generative AI could replace or reduce some of these jobs. And again, women would suffer disproportionately.”

Dropping Out

► India has a high number of female STEM graduates

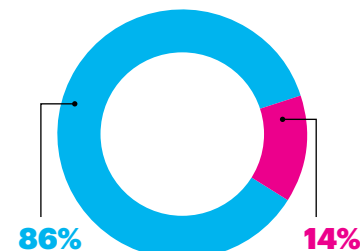
STEM GRADUATES



● MEN ● WOMEN

► But their share drops significantly in STEM-focussed jobs

NO. OF TECHNOLOGISTS, SCIENTISTS AND ENGINEERS

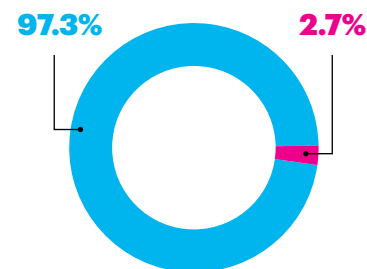


SOURCE THE WORLD BANK

Funding woes

► Funding remains extremely low for women-led start-ups

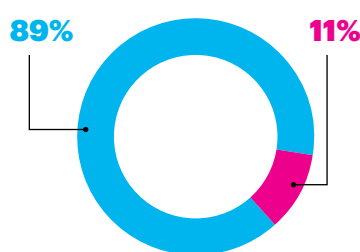
VC FUNDING



● OTHER START-UPS
● START-UPS FOUNDED BY WOMEN

► There are very few women VCs in a position to deploy capital

VC FIRMS



● OTHER VCS
● WHERE WOMEN ARE IN A POSITION TO DEPLOY CAPITAL

SOURCE CRUNCHBASE, HARVARD BUSINESS REVIEW